

Plastics

The first plastic, made in 1856 by the British inventor Alexander Parkes, was formed using a plant-based material called Parkesine, later named cellulose.

In the 1920s, chemists developed plastics from substances in oil. This led to the creation of a variety of plastics, such as polythene. Unfortunately, plastics can take hundreds of years to decompose, resulting in huge waste in landfills and in oceans.

CELLULOID

In the 1860s, a cellulose-based plastic called celluloid was developed by Alexander Parkes. Clear, flexible, and very easy to mold, it was used for many things, from photographic film to kitchen utensils. However, it proved to be extremely flammable and caused many accidents, so it is rarely used today.

FAST FACTS

- Plastic bags were first introduced in supermarkets in 1977. Today, there are approximately 160,000 plastic bags bought globally every second.
- Plastic items, such as water bottles, can take between 400 and 1,000 years to decompose.
- About 10 percent of total global waste is made up of plastic-based items.

The first purpose of celluloid was to make pool balls, however they are made from a different, safer type of plastic today.

